

Reading critically & investigative thinking.

Yesterday you learned to recognise the landscape. Today you learn to interrogate what's in it.

PROGRAMME

Media Literacy Workshops for Young People

Three-day workshop series · Day 2 of 3

TODAY'S PACE

37 slides · 2 hours

~3 min per slide · 2 exercises

PRE-WORKSHOP SURVEY

Scan this before we start.

WHY WE'RE ASKING

A two-minute baseline so we can tailor the day to what you actually need.

A few quick questions on what you already know, what you use, and what you'd like to leave with. Your answers shape the discussion and the examples we come back to.

ANONYMOUS

TWO MINUTES

ANY PHONE CAMERA

SCAN TO OPEN



Open your camera · point at the code

A link will appear · tap it

PICKING UP WHERE WE LEFT OFF

From the landscape to what's in it.

YESTERDAY

The landscape.

Types of media. Algorithms, filter bubbles, echo chambers.
Your rights online. How to spot the fake one in three.

- MIS / DIS / PROPAGANDA / FAKE
- ALGORITHMS
- FILTER BUBBLES
- DIGITAL HYGIENE

TODAY

How to interrogate what's in it.

Three reading habits. Six manipulation tactics. Four ways
propaganda actually scales. Two hands-on exercises.

- HABITS
- TACTICS
- PROPAGANDA
- WRITE YOUR OWN

HOLD THIS FOR THE NEXT TWO HOURS

When you see a piece
of content, how do you
work out whether it is
what it claims to be?

Five things, in this order.

Two hours. Heaviest content in the middle. The thing you'll remember longest is the bit where you write the fake news yourself.

01

Three habits
for reading critically.

02

Six tactics
used to mislead you.

03

Four ways
propaganda actually
scales.

04

One exercise
where you write the fake
news.

05

One game
that puts you in the
producer's seat.

TWO MINUTES. READ BOTH.

Same story. Two outlets.

READING TIMER

START

RESET

02:00

OUTLET A

PREMIUM TIMES NG

POLITICS · 14 MARCH

Lagos Assembly passes Ibeju-Lekki estate bill after eleven-hour sitting

The bill, which authorises a 2,400-unit estate on the Lekki-Epe corridor, passed by 31 votes to 18 shortly after midnight. Opposition members raised concerns about drainage, road access and the schools plan attached to the development.

"We have listened," the chair of the Lands Committee said in remarks delivered just after the vote. The minority leader called the consultation "thorough but rushed at the end". Site works are expected to begin in the third quarter of next year. The bill includes provisions for a ₦4.2 billion infrastructure levy and...

By the Assembly correspondent · premiumtimesng.com

OUTLET B

NAIJA PULSE DAILY

FRONT PAGE · 14 MARCH

Residents furious as lawmakers RAM through 2,400-unit estate in midnight vote

Angry Lekki residents say the Assembly "bulldozed" the controversial estate through a marathon session that ended in the small hours, with concerns about traffic, flooding and overstretched schools brushed aside.

"They didn't listen to us," one Lekki Phase 1 resident told this paper. A community spokesperson called the consultation "a sham conducted in English nobody around here uses". A petition opposing the project has reached 4,000 signatures in 36 hours. The first units could appear on the Lekki-Epe corridor by...

By our correspondent · naijapulse.example.ng

Same Assembly. Same vote. Same hour. What's different, in tone, language, framing, emphasis?

Four lenses for spotting difference.

Captured on the board as the group calls them out. Same four for any pair of articles, anywhere.

01

Tone

Calm vs heightened. Formal vs casual. Reporting vs persuasion.

02

Language

Which words are loaded. Which adjectives appear. What gets called what.

03

Framing

Who's described first. Who's quoted. What context is included, or left out.

04

Emphasis

What's in the headline. What's buried lower down. What never gets said.

THE TAKEAWAY

Bias rarely shows up as outright lies.

WHAT BIAS IS NOT

Not "they made it up."

Most reporting in mainstream outlets is factually defensible. Each individual claim could be sourced.

WHAT BIAS IS

It shows up in choices.

What to include. What to leave out. Whose voice goes first. How an event is described. Which detail leads. Which is buried.

FROM HERE, IT GETS BIGGER

The same techniques, scaled and coordinated, become propaganda.

THE LEAP WE'RE MAKING TODAY

One outlet writing a slanted headline is something. Hundreds of accounts pushing the same slanted framing, on cue, on the same morning, is something else. We'll come back to that in the second half.

FIRST, THOUGH

Three habits.

For reading any piece of content critically, in five minutes, on your own phone.

Then: live demo.

We investigate one real article together, narrated out loud, start to finish.

REUSABLE ACROSS THE REST OF THE MODULE

Three habits.

HABIT · 01

Check for previous coverage.

Search the same story across multiple outlets. If only one obscure source is carrying a major claim, that's information.

HABIT · 02

Go to the source.

Track back to the original study, statement, video, document. The distortion often lives in the gap between source and headline.

HABIT · 03

Read around the article.

Investigate the author, the outlet, the wider information environment. Five minutes. Curiosity, not certainty.

YOU WILL SEE THESE THREE AGAIN

Same numbers, same order, every time. Repetition is part of the teaching.

HABIT · 01

Check for previous coverage.

If a story is genuinely significant, multiple credible outlets will be covering it.

WALK-THROUGH · SAME HEADLINE, THREE SEARCHES

PREMIUM TIMES · TODAY

"FG denies sudden fuel-subsidy reversal, says cited memo is fabricated"

THE GUARDIAN NG · TODAY

"No reversal of subsidy decision, sources clarify"

9JATRENDS24.NG · 4 HRS AGO

"BREAKING: Subsidy returns Monday, secret FEC memo leaked"

Two credible outlets carry the denial. One unfamiliar site carries the "leak". Absence in the mainstream is the signal.

WHAT YOU'RE LOOKING FOR

The story turning up in three or four credible places, Premium Times, Punch, Daily Trust, BBC Pidgin. Not just one. Not just twenty re-shares of the same WhatsApp broadcast.

WHAT IT MEANS IF IT'S MISSING

A "huge" story carried by one unfamiliar blog and nobody else is almost always either niche, exaggerated, or fabricated. Absence is data.

THE FIVE-SECOND VERSION

Copy the headline. Paste into Google or check Dubawa. Look at who else is reporting it.

HABIT · 02

Go to the source.

Most articles report on something, a study, a statement, a video, a document. The original is usually linked or named.

THE GAP TO WATCH

Between what a source *actually says* and what an article *claims it says*, that gap is where information distorts.

WHAT TO DO

Click the link. Read the paragraph the headline pulled from. Note what the headline added, and what it dropped.

WHEN THERE'S NO LINK

That itself is information. A report on "a new study" with no citation deserves more scepticism than a quiet correction would.

WORKED EXAMPLE · HEADLINE VS THE ACTUAL NBS REPORT

THE HEADLINE

"Inflation hits 40%, Nigerians can no longer afford garri, NBS reveals"

WHAT THE NBS BULLETIN ACTUALLY SAYS

Headline inflation: 33.2% (year-on-year). Food inflation in the *North-East zone*: 40.1%. National food index: 35.4%.

The gap: the article used a regional food figure as the national headline number. The original is one click away. Habit 02 catches this in under a minute.

HABIT · 03

Read around the article.

Three things to look at. None requires special tools. All take under a minute.

A

The author

- Do they exist?
- What else have they written?
- What's their record?

B

The outlet

- When was it founded?
- Who owns it?
- What's its editorial position?

C

The wider environment

- What other coverage exists?
- Who's responding to it?
- Where did the claim originate?

These are habits, not one-offs.

THE SIZE OF THE COMMITMENT

Five minutes. Phone in hand.
Multiple times a day.

Not "set aside an evening for investigation". The whole point is that the bar is low enough to clear it casually, in the time you'd otherwise spend doom-scrolling.

THE DISPOSITION THAT MAKES IT WORK

Curiosity, not certainty.

The goal isn't to "prove it's fake". The goal is to know more about what you're looking at than you did sixty seconds ago.

WATCH IT HAPPEN

One article. Five minutes. Headline to verdict.

Narrated live by the Lead Trainer. Article swapped per cohort so it stays current.

TODAY'S ARTICLE · PROJECTED FOR THE ROOM

NAIJANEWSNOW.ONLINE · YESTERDAY

"Harvard study: 7 in 10 Nigerian youths planning to japa within 24 months"

By "Editorial Desk" · 18k WhatsApp shares

- Habit 01, a Google search returns the same headline copied across three unfamiliar blogs. Premium Times, Punch, Daily Trust: silent.
- Habit 02, the "Harvard study" is not on harvard.edu. The closest match is a 2019 Afrobarometer brief on youth migration intent across Africa.
- Habit 03, "Editorial Desk" has no byline anywhere. The domain was registered 11 weeks ago. Dubawa has flagged a similar claim from the same domain.
- Verdict in five minutes: not a fabrication, a distortion. Real underlying data, reframed as something it isn't.

FOLLOWING THE SAME THREE HABITS

HABIT · 01

Previous coverage

HABIT · 02

Source

HABIT · 03

Author / outlet / environment

What that just showed.

REFRAMING 01

Investigative reading is not specialist work.

You don't need a press card, a journalism degree, or a paid subscription. You need a search bar and curiosity.

REFRAMING 02

It's a five-minute habit. Anyone can do it.

Including the person who shared the article with you.
Including the person you'll share this technique with this week.

SECOND HALF · THE TACTICS

How content gets engineered to mislead.

COMING UP · FIRST

Six tactics that show up again and again.

Each on its own slide, with a Nigerian-context sample, so the pattern is visible rather than abstract.

COMING UP · THEN

How those same tactics scale into propaganda.

Combined. Coordinated. Cross-platform. The move from "misleading post" to "campaign".

None of these are new. They're the same rhetorical and persuasion tactics political operators have used for a hundred years, just running through faster, cheaper, more measurable channels.

TACTIC · 01

Fearmongering.



Make the consequences feel imminent, severe, and personal, to push the reader past careful judgement.

Fear bypasses analysis. By the time you've thought about whether the claim is true, you've already shared it. That's the whole design.

SAMPLE HEADLINE

CIRCULATED ON
WHATSAPP

"URGENT: New SIM-registration deadline tomorrow, millions of lines will be disconnected BEFORE THE WEEKEND." Loaded words do the work; the actual NCC announcement was a routine 90-day notice.

COUNTER-MOVE

Notice the pulse-rate change. Slow down. Apply the three habits before reacting.

TACTIC · 02

Fake experts & credentials.

TACTIC · 02

Expert?

"Borrowed authority. Wrong subject. Out of context."

Authority that doesn't hold up when you look at it.

Three flavours: invented qualifications, real credentials applied to the wrong subject, and genuine experts quoted out of context to support a position they don't actually hold.

INVENTED

"Dr." with no traceable practice or institution.

WRONG FIELD

Engineering PhD speaking on vaccines.

OUT OF CONTEXT

Real quote, cropped to mean the opposite.

SAMPLE BYLINE
FORWARDED CHAIN
MESSAGE

"Dr. C. Okonkwo, Senior Consultant, Lagos Institute of Public Health, warns..." A Dubawa search returns no Lagos Institute of Public Health. No registered MDCN number. No published work. The "borrowed" credential is doing all the persuasion.

TACTIC · 03

Conspiracy framing.

THE MOVE

Complex events presented as the work of a hidden coordinated group.

Reality is usually messy, bad incentives, mistakes, structural problems, competing interests. Conspiracy framing replaces that mess with a single hidden actor pulling all the strings.

WHY IT TRAPS YOU

Every contradicting fact gets a sinister explanation. Inquiry closes down.

"They would say that, wouldn't they." "Of course there's no evidence, that's how good the cover-up is." Once you're inside the frame, no outside data can reach you.

Tell-tale: a worldview where the powerful are *always* in coordination, never in conflict, never incompetent, never just unlucky.

TACTIC · 04

Emotional manipulation.

Content engineered to provoke outrage, disgust, fear, or righteous excitement, because emotional content travels further and faster than neutral content.

SAME STORY · TWO FRAMINGS · TWO OUTCOMES

NEUTRAL

"NERC approves 12% tariff review for Band A customers, citing higher gas costs."

Reach: 4.2k · Shares: 180

OUTRAGE FRAMING

"They've done it AGAIN, FG quietly slips electricity tariff hike past Nigerians while we sleep."

Reach: 380k · Shares: 22k

Same NERC announcement. One word swap, "review" to "hike", and a betrayal verb ("slips past") moves it ~90× further on the feed.

WHY IT WORKS ON YOU

Emotion compresses the time between "seeing" and "sharing". You react before you've finished reading.

WHY IT WORKS ON THE ALGORITHM

Strong reactions = more engagement signals. The system reads "people are responding" and serves it to more people.

COUNTER-MOVE

If the post made you feel something fast, that's the moment to do the three habits, not to tap share.

TACTIC · 05

Clickbait & curiosity gaps.

Headlines designed to extract a click by withholding information. Promise far more than the article delivers.

THREE NIGERIAN-FEED HEADLINES · WHAT THE ARTICLE ACTUALLY DELIVERED

"You won't believe what this Big Brother housemate said next..."

→ *you would, easily, it's two sentences of small talk*

"SHOCKING truth about garri Lagos doctors don't want you to know"

→ *article is a recycled blog post on portion sizes*

"This Lagos-based banker quit her job, what she's doing now will surprise you"

→ *she sells small chops · the surprise is not surprising*

The reveal almost never matches the size of the promise. That gap is the business model.

WHY IT WORKS

A curiosity gap is uncomfortable. The brain wants the gap closed, even if the answer is trivial.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

Your time, your data, and the slow training of expecting reality to deliver "shocking truths" every scroll.

TELL-TALE

If the headline could be answered in one word and isn't, that's the gap.

TACTIC · 06

False equivalence.

THE MOVE

Two sides presented as equally weighted when the evidence behind them isn't.

"Balanced coverage" that gives the same screen time to a position with mountains of evidence and a position with almost none. The visual symmetry hides the asymmetry of the actual data.

WATCH FOR

"Some say... others say..." with no weighing of who is right and on what.

WHY IT MATTERS

Lends unearned legitimacy to fringe positions.

A fringe claim placed next to a mainstream finding is a fringe claim that has just inherited the visual authority of "this is one of two reasonable sides".

A USEFUL ASK

"What's the actual weight of evidence on each side here?"

04

The propaganda landscape.

The six tactics aren't only used by individual creators chasing engagement. They're also the building blocks of organised propaganda, the same moves, combined at scale.

FOUR SHAPES TO RECOGNISE

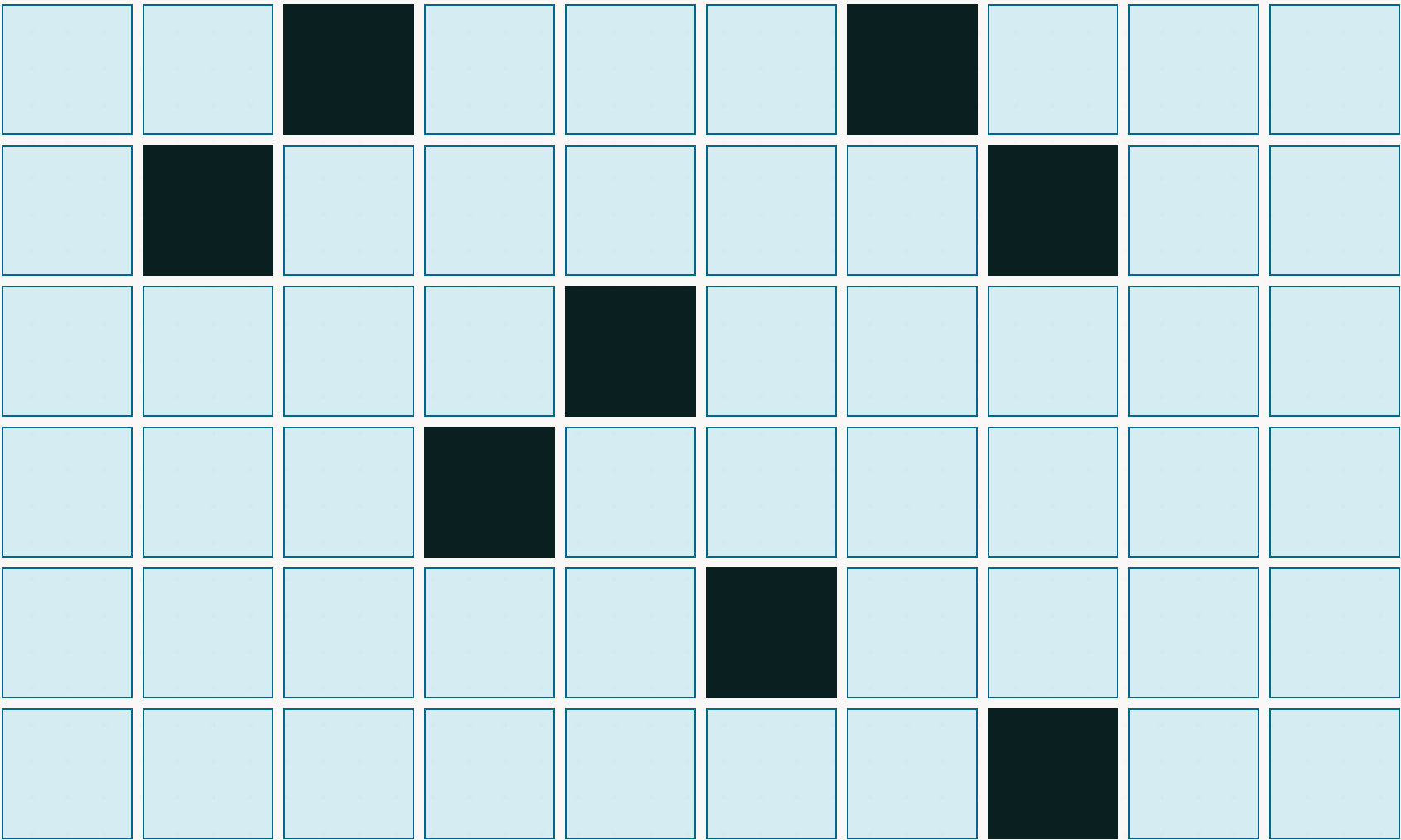
25 → 28

SHAPE · 01

Coordinated inauthentic behaviour.

Networks of fake accounts and bots. Amplify content to make a position look more popular, or more contested, than it actually is.

A SWARM, MOST "VOICES" ARE NOT PEOPLE



Light Blue Inauthentic / amplifier Black Real account

WHAT IT MAKES YOU FEEL

"Everyone agrees with this." Or, sometimes, "this is enormously contested." Both can be manufactured.

TELL-TALES

Accounts with no history before this month. Identical posting times. Generic profile pictures. Near-identical bios.

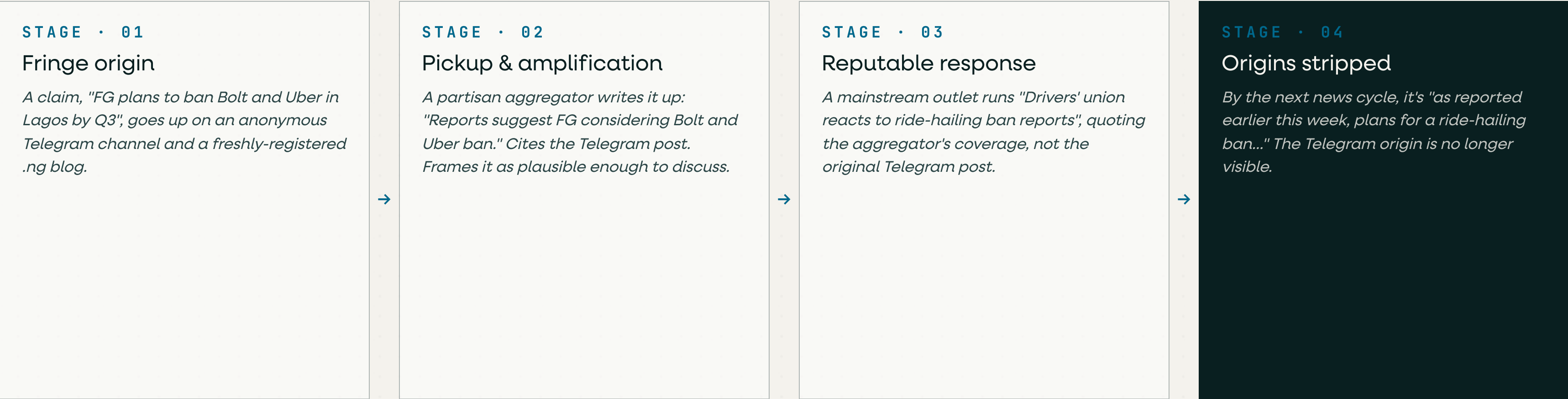
DOCUMENTED CASE

Stanford Internet Observatory's 2020 take-down of a Nigeria-linked network: ~270 accounts running coordinated pro-government and anti-opposition hashtags around the #EndSARS period. Catalogued by Dubawa and DFRLab.

SHAPE · 02

Narrative laundering.

A claim starts somewhere unreliable, gets picked up by something slightly more mainstream, and eventually appears in respectable coverage with its origins stripped out.



The point: by stage 04, a claim that started on a Telegram channel now wears the clothes of credible reporting. *Habit 02, go to the source, is what walks it back.*

SHAPE · 03

Astroturfing.

Organised activity dressed up as a spontaneous grassroots reaction. Stock language. Template comments. Repeated across many accounts.

SAMPLE · COMMENTS UNDER A SINGLE POST

@user_71203 · 14:02 "Absolutely outrageous. Concerned parents will not stand for this."	@user_71412 · 14:03 "Outrageous! Concerned parents will not stand for this."	@user_71588 · 14:03 "Absolutely outrageous! Concerned parents will not stand for this."
@user_71601 · 14:05 "Hmm, this seems badly framed. Anyone got the original?"	@user_71777 · 14:06 "Concerned parents will absolutely not stand for this. Outrageous."	@user_71891 · 14:07 "Outrageous! As a concerned parent I will not stand for this."

Highlighted comments share near-identical phrasing, timing, and account-naming pattern.

WHAT IT TRIES TO MANUFACTURE

The impression of an organic mass reaction, to give a campaign the moral weight of "ordinary people are upset".

TELL-TALES

Repeated phrasing. Suspiciously similar usernames. Accounts that never post about anything else.

WHY IT MATTERS

"Spontaneous public outrage" is a powerful political signal. Faking it short-circuits the democratic process the signal is meant to reflect.

SHAPE · 04

Influence operations.

Media manipulation as a tool of foreign policy, political competition, or commercial interest. State actors. Non-state actors. Sometimes both at once.

A**State actors**

National governments running media-manipulation operations against domestic populations, foreign populations, or both, often through cut-outs that don't visibly carry state branding.

B**Non-state actors**

Political campaigns, commercial PR firms, ideological movements, and contract operators-for-hire, running the same playbooks, often with the same suppliers.

C**Both at once**

A state hires a private firm; the firm rents from a contractor; the contractor uses the same bot network it sold to a corporate client last quarter. The lines aren't clean, and aren't meant to be.

WORTH KNOWING

You probably can't fully attribute a campaign on your own. You *can* recognise that one is happening.

THE PRINCIPLE THIS MODULE RESTS ON

Recognising propaganda is **not** the same as agreeing or disagreeing with a political position.

It's seeing when content has been engineered, by whom, and why.

GROUPS OF 3 OR 4 · 15 MINUTES

Your turn. Write the fake news.

WRITING TIMER

START

RESET

15:00

THE BRIEF

- 1. Groups of three or four.
- 2. Pick a topic from the cards.
- 3. Use at least three of the manipulation tactics we covered.
- 4. Name the tactics in the margins as you go.
- 5. Write a headline you think people would actually click on.

TOPIC CARDS · LIGHT + LOW-STAKES

CARD 01

A new NYSC posting rule

CARD 02

A Nollywood / BBN scandal

CARD 03

A local "tech breakthrough"

CARD 04

A surprise discovery in your LGA

CARD 05

A "leaked" WhatsApp voice note

WILD CARD

Your own, keep it light

Rule of thumb: nothing about real people in the room. Nothing that could be mistaken for a real claim once it leaves the room.

WHAT 'GOOD' LOOKS LIKE

Plausible. Emotional. Lightly sourced. Hard to scroll past.

EXAMPLE

NAIJA PULSE 247

BREAKING · TODAY · LAGOS

EXCLUSIVE: Lagos secondary school SECRETLY trialling controversial new policy, parents kept in the dark, experts "deeply concerned"

An unnamed source close to the principal said the move would "fundamentally change school life by third term". Anonymous parents from the school's WhatsApp group described the situation as "outrageous" and "a betrayal of trust".

No member of staff has confirmed the policy publicly. No circular has been seen. A respected educationalist, "Dr. M. Adeyemi", with credentials in an unrelated field, said it raises "serious questions for every Nigerian parent". The full picture remains unclear, but those briefed described it as...

By "Education Desk" · naijapulse247.example.ng

TACTICS LABELLED IN THE MARGINS

T1

Fearmongering, "SECRETLY", "fundamentally change", "betrayal".

T2

Fake expert, "Dr. Adeyemi" credentialed in an unrelated field; not in any MDCN or NUC register.

T3

Emotional manipulation, outrage, betrayal, parental anxiety stacked.

T4

Clickbait headline, withholds the actual policy, promises a reveal.

T5

Anonymous sources, every concrete claim is one WhatsApp-group step removed.

FULLY-LABELLED REFERENCE · STAYS ON SCREEN WHILE GROUPS WRITE

LEAVE THIS UP WHILE GROUPS WRITE

Six tactics. Pick three.

A reference card. Stays on the screen during the writing portion of the exercise.

01 Fearmongering

02 Fake experts & credentials

03 Conspiracy framing

04 Emotional manipulation

05 Clickbait & curiosity gaps

06 False equivalence

IN YOUR MARGINS

Label the tactic each line of your article is using. The labels are what we'll debrief on.

EACH GROUP · BRIEFLY

Debrief.

DEBRIEF
10:00

START

RESET

Q1

Which of these would you have shared, if a friend posted it without context?

Q2

Which tactics were hardest to resist using?

Q3

What changes about how you'll read content from now on?

The visceral point: once you've made the misleading content yourself, you can't un-see how it gets made. That's the goal of this exercise.

PLAY TIME

Bad News.

PLAY TIMER

08:00

START

RESET

WHAT IT IS

A free browser game where you play the fake-news producer.

Build an audience using the same six tactics we just covered. Discover which ones scale fastest, and which ones backfire.

SOLO OR PAIRS

~8 MINUTES

PHONE OR LAPTOP

PLAY HERE



SHORT URL

getbadnews.com

After you've played.

Q1

Which tactics felt most powerful inside the game?

Q2

Why?

Notice which moves felt like cheating, and which felt like normal posting.

THREE MINUTES · WRITE YOUR ANSWERS DOWN

Pass it on.

QUIET TIME

03:00

START

RESET

PROMPT · 01

One thing from today you'll explain to a friend or family member this week.

Whichever felt most useful, or most surprising. Doesn't have to be the whole module. One thing, one conversation.

PROMPT · 02

One piece of content you'll look at differently the next time you see it.

A type of post, a kind of headline, a particular account, a recurring narrative, whatever this module has changed your eye for.

TOMORROW

Day 3, Fact-checking.

DAY 03 · PREVIEW

Today: read it apart. Tomorrow: check it.

From recognising manipulation into verifying claims, with real tools, real platforms, and a closing exercise that brings everything from all three days together.

TOPIC · 01

CRAAP test

TOPIC · 02

Triangulation

TOPIC · 03

AI-generated content

TOPIC · 04

Real tools, real posts

BRING WITH YOU

- Your group's fake article from today.
- Your two pass-it-on answers.
- A piece of content you want to fact-check together.

HEADS UP

Day 3 is a lab. Phones out. Real searches. We'll close the programme with a single shared exercise.

THANK YOU

See you tomorrow.

You came in able to spot the difference between two articles. You leave with three habits, six tactics, four campaign shapes, one piece of fake news with your name on it, and the most important reframe of the programme: *recognising propaganda is not the same as agreeing or disagreeing with a position. It's seeing when content has been engineered.*

01

Three reading habits.

Previous coverage. Source. Read around. Five minutes, on your phone.

02

Six tactics, four shapes.

Misleading content has a vocabulary. So does the larger machinery around it.

03

One thing to pass on.

One person. One conversation. Before Day 3.